associated with West Berlin's Kommune 1 were arrested in conjunction with a plan to stage a symbolic "pudding assassination" on visiting vice president Hubert Humphrey with confectionary and flour. The harsh arrest of the planners of this action fueled massive protests that merged with others held around the visit to West Berlin of the Shah of Iran, a Western ally who claimed power during a CIA-assisted coup in 1953. (Angela Davis remarked on the latter protests in her autobiography, and future students of Tajiri's were incensed by the overwhelming repressive backlash in this period.) During the Shah's visit, protestors were met with violent reproach from the police, with one student, Benno Ohnesorg, shot by authorities. Such confrontations reflected the fragile relationship between authorities and younger residents in West Germany, which spiked activism directed at U.S. and allied institutions. This fueled a growing counterculture of dissent and radicalism in the city and the shift away from the Wall as the primary site of conflict in West Berlin.[17]

Such shifts in political attention and cultural attitudes about the Wall also coincided with a surge in artistic experimentation in West Berlin around the actual space of the border wall by the likes of Tajiri, Allan Kaprow, Christo and Jeanne-Claude, and a host of others. The evolving nature of the Wall, viewed as both a structural monstrosity and an environment inviting close-up exploration, was ripe for artists looking to question its contours. Claudia Mesch suggests, "A number of artists in West Berlin, several Americans among them, based their work on the material aspects of the postwar city space and of the objects and detritus that littered it."[18] The heightened attention to a standardized walled separation contrasted with loosened attitudes about direct or nearby engagement with the western area adjacent to the Wall. Though illicit, casually sanctioned graffiti on the Wall became a visual staple in the mid-1970s, a cohort of artists who encroached on the Wall did so with their eyes on its materiality and strange landscape.

A new cohort of conceptual artists aimed for institutional political critiques of social systems and the art world beyond their immediate composition, eager to work in and on Berlin. The Wall's sprawling context compelled them to incorporate it into projects amenable to conceptual art's broad, pointed aims. Tony Godfrey notes, "Conceptual art challenges the traditional status of the art object as unique, collectable, or saleable. Because the work does not take a traditional form, it demands a more active response from the viewer."[19] Godfrey distinguishes four classifications of conceptual